

The Algorithm Will Not Babysit: Chinese Women's Conception of
Fertility in the Tension between Birth Policy Propaganda and Fertility
Posts on Xiaohongshu and Douyin

By Lu Gao

July, 2025

A paper submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the
Master of Arts degree in the

Master of Arts Program in the Social Sciences

Faculty Advisor: Linda Waite

Preceptor: Damien Bright

Abstract: Against the backdrop of a continuous decline in China's fertility rate and the interwoven tensions of gender politics, this study, based on over 48,000 comments on Xiaohongshu and Douyin, as well as in-depth interviews with 12 women, explores how cyber feminism uses algorithmic recommendations to reach ordinary women and reshape fertility concepts through emotional resonance and structural oppression. Research has found that physical pain, along with economic and childcare burdens, jointly shape the fear of having children. The dual pressure of national propaganda and family expectations has intensified the tug of war at women between moral narratives and personal planning. The platform algorithm not only amplifies anxiety but also promotes awakening, transforming private pain into public criticism. Cyberfeminism has thus given rise to the "conditional fertility" strategy, revealing the structural dilemmas behind low fertility rates and women's autonomous practices, and providing insights for future fertility policies and gender equality.

Keywords: Cyberfeminism; Fertility and gender; China's birth policy; Computational Text Analysis

Introduction

In recent years, China's population and fertility trends have shown an unprecedented downturn. In 2022, the number of births in the country fell below 10 million, the first negative population growth since the 1960s, and the fertility rate fell to the bottom of the world (National Bureau of Statistics, 2023). Under the pressure of the aging population, the Chinese Communist Party & State Council has successively canceled the one-child policy and implemented the "comprehensive two-child policy" (2015) and the "three-child policy" (2021) to try to reverse the decline in the birth rate. However, these top-down initiatives have had little effect, and there is a huge gap between the state's policy discourse on encouraging childbearing and the actual response of the female population. Party and government organs and mainstream scholars are worried about the so-called "population crisis" and "decline of national strength" and set raising fertility rate as a national strategic goal (Greenhalgh, 2024, p. 57). With the general improvement of women's education level and economic independence, women's self-awareness is gradually improving. Women's requirements and expectations for childbirth are also higher, and the demonstration of self-worth is also improving (Renmin Think Tank, 2023, p. 16). However, many Chinese women have a wait-and-see attitude and even resist childbirth, and the Internet is full of doubts and rebellion against the "fertility mission" (Chen & Ding, 2024, p. 145).

In this context, it is necessary to take an in-depth look at the tension between national fertility policy and women's rights. China's fertility policy reflects the discipline and expectations of national governance on the population, but it has triggered a growing sense of autonomy and resistance among women. More Chinese women are beginning to reflect on their position within the structures of marriage and childbearing. Having witnessed and personally experienced institutional and cultural forms of oppression, they are developing a new awareness of their bodies and reproductive rights, a consciousness that is converging into a

powerful feminist wave in cyberspace. This awakening of women's reproductive rights is manifested not only in the rejection of the traditional patriarchal role of fertility (such as actively choosing not to marry and have children), but also in powerful countermeasures to the national reproductive discourse (such as questioning the fairness and legitimacy of policies in public opinion) (Zhang & Zhao, 2023, p35). This study builds on that transformation to ask: How do national fertility policies shape and constrain women's reproductive roles, and how do women, in turn, adopt and adapt feminist critiques, particularly through digital platforms, to resist and reimagine those roles?



Public service poster: "Please avoid non-policy-based and non-medically necessary induced abortions."

Provided by an anonymous interviewee

By analyzing large-scale discussions on Xiaohongshu, Douyin and semi-structured interviews, this study highlights the algorithmic mechanisms that spread feminist narratives beyond activist circles, enabling ordinary women who were previously not politicized to come into contact with these narratives. In this process, the research has clarified the dynamic interaction between national governance and online feminism and holds that the decline in the birth rate is not merely the result of "feminist distraction", but rather evidence of women collectively striving for physical sovereignty and social dignity. This perspective offers important insights into the constantly changing gender political landscape in contemporary

China and provides a reference point for formulating fairer and more sensitive population policies.

Research Questions and Hypotheses

This study explores how the pessimistic narrative surrounding motherhood in the digital feminist space intersects with contemporary fertility policies in China and how this intersection influences the fertility decisions of young women. By analyzing the discourse circulating on social media platforms such as Xiaohongshu and Douyin, this study attempts to reveal how these narratives have been magnified, reconstructed and mobilized in the broader evolution of online feminism in China. This study attempts to closely examine how these competing discourses play a promoting and pulling role at the individual decision-making level. The pessimistic and rational criticism in the feminist space has had the opposite effect, highlighting the physical, emotional and economic costs of motherhood and exposing the structural inequalities that have long been the norm. The core issue of the research is how these anti-narratives respond to national policies and persistent patriarchal expectations, reshaping women's concepts of motherhood and autonomy.

The assumption behind this exploration is that the narrative of online feminism reconfigures the meanings of fertility and motherhood in contemporary China. This study hypothesizes that algorithmic recommendation systems have played a crucial role in spreading these narratives beyond the traditional feminist circle, enabling women who have not actively sought feminist content to access other reproductive perspectives and, in some cases, reconsider their life trajectories.

Literature Context

China's fertility policy has shifted from strict population control to active encouragement of childbirth, while consistently subordinating women's autonomy to national demographic goals (Greenhalgh, 2024). Entering the 21st century, the rapid aging of the population and

labor shortages prompted pronatalist reforms on structural barriers: workplace discrimination, childcare scarcity, cost pressures, remain unaddressed (Ge & Shi, 2021; Chan & Cheang, 2023). Surveys reveal overwhelming public reluctance toward having multiple children, signaling a divergence between state rationality and women's lived realities.

Feminism's migration into digital space has been shaped by political suppression. Feminist debates, once confined to academic and NGO spaces, have moved onto platforms like Xiaohongshu and Douyin, where algorithmic encounters expose previously apolitical women to feminist critiques (Bao, 2024; Chen & Ding, 2024). As Baer & Ding (2023) note, algorithms prioritize emotional resonance, unintentionally amplifying feminist expression while subjecting it to censorship. This contradictory visibility creates volatile yet powerful expansions of feminist consciousness.

Family expectations constitute another domain where push and pull forces shape reproductive decisions (Du, 2022; Cong & Silverstein, 2014). Intergenerational childcare eases economic strain yet also reinforces moral expectations of childbearing. Structural pressures, healthcare inequities, childcare scarcity, economic precarity, intensify skepticism toward pronatalist policies (Chang & Wang, 2022; Tan & Kang, 2021; UNFPA China, 2024).

These structural and discursive landscapes contextualize the study's focus on algorithmic dissemination of feminist narratives.

Methodology

This study adopts an explanatory sequential mixed-methods approach (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018), combining public comment data from Xiaohongshu and Douyin with semi-structured interviews. The theoretical framework integrates a rational choice model of fertility (Becker, 1991) with a discourse-power perspective (Foucault, 1978; Yuval-Davis, 1997).

The quantitative data was collected by scraping the top 10 posts (by comment volume) under user-provided hashtags such as “childbirth,” “pregnancy,” and “three children,” followed by extraction of the top 10% most-liked primary comments from each post. After cleaning, 48,326 valid comments remained, each labeled with a sentiment score and categorized by fertility attitude using keyword rules and machine learning. The qualitative component consists of 12 semi-structured interviews conducted between March and April 2025.

An important methodological consideration is the influence of algorithmic recommendation systems. The comments analyzed in this study were collected from accounts that may have been classified by the platforms as interested in feminist or reproductive topics. Interview recruitment on Xiaohongshu and Douyin is subject to similar biases. Rather than treating this as a limitation, this study incorporates it into the analytic framework: the same algorithmic forces that bias data collection are those that structure the diffusion of feminist narratives online. Ethical safeguards include anonymization of all data, informed consent from interviewees, and ethics approval by the university review board.

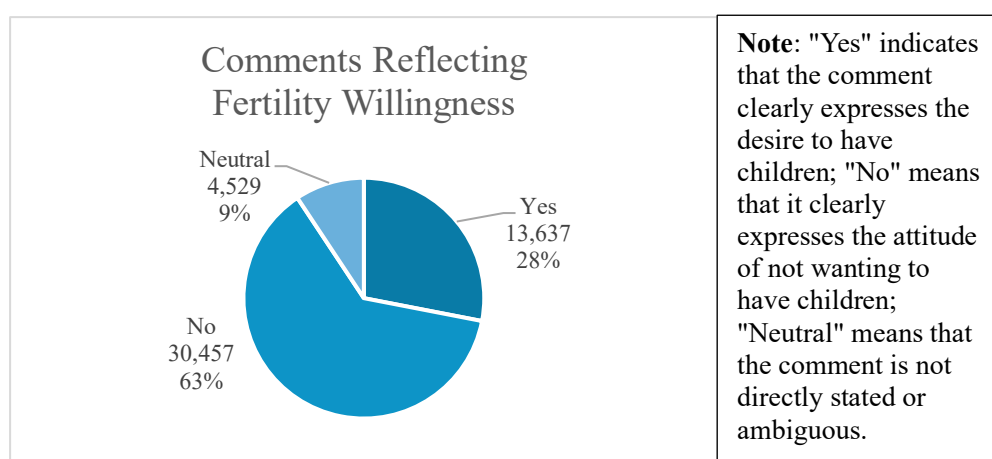
Overview of Findings

This section synthesizes the quantitative and qualitative results derived from the mixed-methods design detailed earlier. The combined dataset of 48,623 valid Xiaohongshu and Douyin comments, supplemented by 12 semi-structured interviews provides a comprehensive foundation for analyzing China’s contemporary fertility discourse. Following an explanatory sequential logic, the quantitative comment analysis identifies dominant attitudinal patterns and discursive structures, which are then elaborated through interview data that reveal individual meaning-making and negotiation processes. The results demonstrate how digital platforms serve as both sites of feminist consciousness formation and arenas where reproductive anxieties, structural evaluations, and algorithmic encounters converge. The computational component identifies seven prominent categories of fertility reasoning and

quantifies the prevalence and emotional intensity of each, while qualitative interviews validate and contextualize these findings, highlighting algorithmic mechanisms, emotional catalysts, and structural constraints. Taken together, the findings underscore how cyberfeminist narratives move far beyond isolated expressions of fear or dissatisfaction, instead forming a cohesive discursive field that challenges state pronatalism and reconfigures women's reproductive autonomy.

Results

A total of 58,983 comments were collected from Xiaohongshu and Douyin. The data was scraped from the most debated posts (by number of comments) under hashtags related to

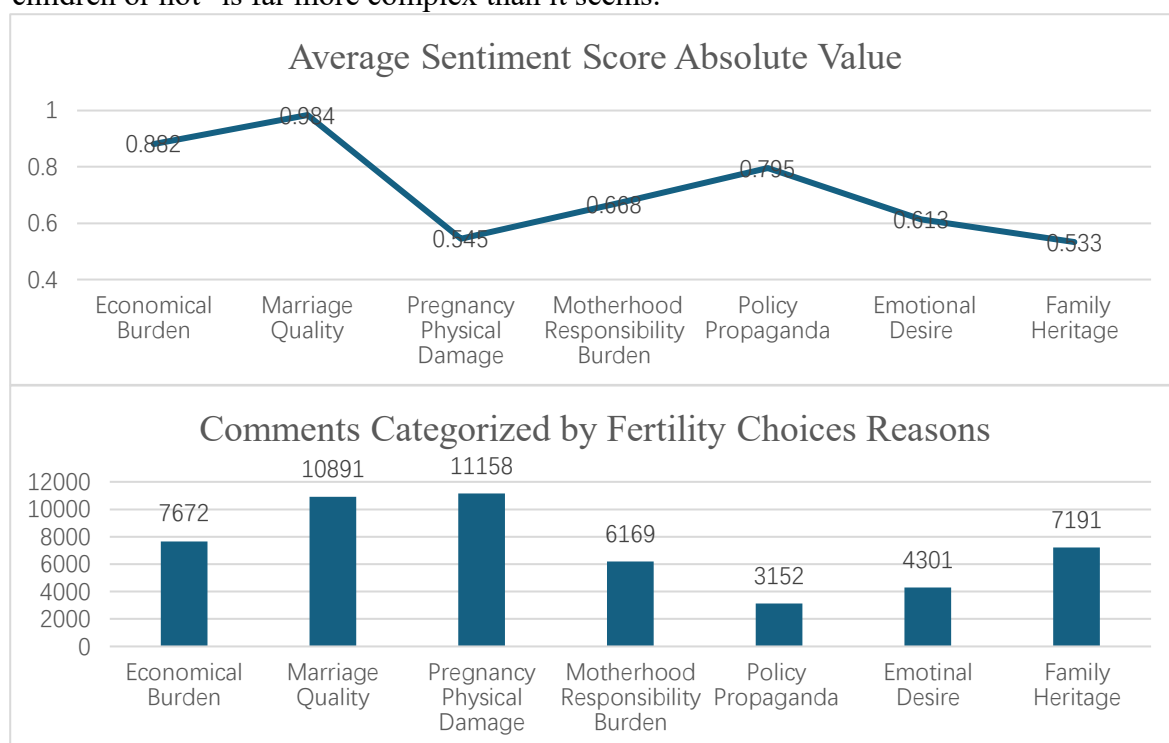


fertility, such as “childbirth,” “having a child,” and “pregnancy”, which were originally identified by participants in the qualitative interviews. From each hashtag, the top 10 posts with the highest comment volume were selected. Within each post, the top 10% of most-liked primary comments were extracted for analysis. After removing duplicates and non-substantive content, 48,623 valid comments remained. These were then labeled with sentiment score and categorized based on the fertility intentions expressed by the users, as summarized in the following table.

The descriptive analysis of the 48,623 valid comments scraped from Xiaohongshu and Douyin confirms the presence of a large-scale public discourse that actively contests mainstream narratives on fertility. A majority of the comments (63%) clearly expressed

unwillingness to have children, with only 28% expressing a positive fertility intention. The most cited reasons for rejecting childbirth include physical damage from pregnancy (11,158 mentions), concerns about marriage quality (10,891), and economic burden (7,672). These findings echo the themes that emerged in the qualitative interviews, in which participants frequently linked reproductive decisions to fears of maternal health damage, gender injustice within marriage, and insufficient childcare support.

In the text analysis of this study, we identified seven dominant reproductive considerations from 48,623 valid comments, including economic burden, marriage quality, pregnancy physical damage, motherhood responsibility burden, policy propaganda, emotional desire and family heritage. This classification combines the keywords automatically identified by the emotion model with the real predicaments frequently mentioned by the women in the interviews, reflecting that their thinking path when facing the choice of "whether to have children or not" is far more complex than it seems.



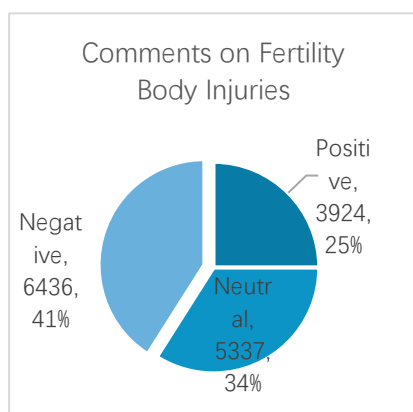
These classifications are specific questions raised by women in real situations. Their willingness to have children is not only related to their personal desires, but also closely linked to their judgments on the marriage system, gender division of labor and the allocation

of public resources. These seven categories not only originated from keyword clustering in social media texts but were also verified through the topic coding of interviews. For instance, concerns over physical harm to pregnant and postpartum women were the most prominent negative theme in the comments, and this was also echoed in the interview narratives. This consistency across data types enhanced the reliability of the analysis.

A notable pattern emerging from both the comment analysis and interviews is the role of algorithmic “serendipity” in exposing ordinary users to feminist discourse. Among the twelve interviewees, nine reported that they first encountered cyberfeminist narratives via passive recommendations while browsing unrelated content or seeking advice on relationship and fertility dilemmas. For example, several participants described scrolling through lifestyle or parenting forums only to be “pushed” posts critiquing gender roles or highlighting childbirth risks, which they later traced as their entry point into broader feminist communities. This unintentional exposure often preceded more systematic exploration of feminist ideas and, over time, shaped how these women framed their own reproductive choices. The findings suggest that algorithmic recommendation mechanisms not only expand the reach of feminist narratives beyond self-identified activists also normalize feminist framings in everyday digital environments, subtly reframing how young women in China negotiate family expectations and pronatalist pressures.

Sentiment Patterns in Physical Injury Discourse

As a short extension of the pregnancy physical damage part, a notable number total of 15,697 comments were screened out about fertility injury keywords (such as stretch marks, uterine prolapse, etc.) in the review content. The distribution of sentiment tendencies (positive/neutral/negative) for these reviews is as follows:



Emotionally, comments tied to “pregnancy injury” recorded significantly lower sentiment scores (average absolute score = 0.543), signaling deep affective aversion and disillusionment. Among the 15,697 comments specifically referencing physical harm from childbirth, 41% conveyed negative sentiments, compared to only 25% that were

explicitly positive. These patterns reflect the logic of feminist consciousness formation previously outlined: personal pain is increasingly interpreted through a structural lens. Taken together, the quantitative data not only reinforce the themes of gendered cost, structural distrust, and discursive resistance identified in the interviews, also demonstrate how these critiques have diffused across digital public space.

Discussion

The Emotional Foundations of Digital Feminism

Fear vs. lived bodily experience plays a significant role in shaping women’s resistance to pronatalist narratives. A striking finding from both the comment analysis and interviews is the centrality of bodily pain and fear in shaping women’s resistance to pronatalist narratives. As the comment analysis shows, physical trauma from childbirth is the most cited reason behind fertility reluctance (11,158 comments), and its associated comments show the lowest average sentiment score (0.545), indicating intense emotional negativity.

This observation is echoed in interviews. One participant, Li Dapeng, recounted how growing up in a family with traditional fertility values made her internalize motherhood as destiny, until she encountered feminist bloggers and reading groups through a friend. “That pain wasn’t just mine,” she reflected, “it was repeated in every woman’s story I read.” This transformation mirrors the “oppression–awakening–identity–action” mechanism described in the literature (Tong, 2020). Bao’s (2024) Weibo corpus study demonstrates these cases of

gender-based violence have become not just media events, but emotional ignition points. The surge of negative sentiments in public comments reflected women's reassessment of the marriage and childbirth system.

This online emotional transmission forms what Yang (2024) calls "shared pain consciousness", a feminist awakening through the circulation of grief and rage. A single post of fury can echo with thousands. The pain of one woman becomes a resonant node, triggering further awakenings. As one netizen put it: "I didn't know I was a feminist, until I saw what could happen to someone like me." In this sense, the digital sphere becomes a generator of political energy. Feminism, then, becomes the language through which personal wounds are connected and politicized. The process turns private trauma into public discourse, thus shifting "what hurts" into "what must be changed."

The awakening of feminist consciousness often originates from the tangible pain women encounter in the forms of reproductive risk, workplace discrimination, or emotional violence in marriage. This kind of individual realization reflects a broader mechanism: women endure oppression in the forms of reproductive risk, workplace discrimination, or emotional violence in marriage, and in seeking to make sense of their confusion and fear, they turn to online spaces where private suffering meets shared narratives. Tong (2020, p. 65) aptly describes this process as the transformation of "private pain into public structural awareness."

Critical public events often catalyze this reflection. As Bao (2024) notes, gender-based violence cases such as the Fengxian chained mother and the Tangshan restaurant beating spurred massive discussion on Weibo. Many interviewees mentioned that these incidents made them reconsider the safety and fairness of the reproductive system in China. "If a tragedy like hers could happen, would we still dare to get married?" One interviewee asked. These moments have become selling points of cyberfeminism, and they are also the starting points of the awakening of women's group consciousness. Yang (2024) powerfully captures

this turn: "There's a painful reason dripping blood behind every Chinese woman who dare to stand up against patriarchy." As pain is shared and circulated online, what begins as personal grief becomes collective anger, and ultimately, political consciousness.

Algorithmic Amplification and the Computational Structure of Feminist Diffusion

A notable finding drawn from comment analysis and interviews is that algorithmic recommendation systems passively push feminist content to users who do not explicitly seek feminist content. As Milford (2015) emphasized in "algorithmic encounters", the recommendation logic prioritizes the content that triggers emotional responses: anger, frustration or unity, rather than political stance. Many respondents recalled the gender-related "algorithmic encounters" they posted while browsing daily entertainment on Douyin or Xiaohongshu, which made them realize that their personal dissatisfaction was part of a broader structural problem.

This finding directly speaks to your computational social science contribution: the combination of NLP-derived reasoning categories and qualitative testimony reveals how algorithmic affordances shape the discursive field of fertility politics. This is consistent with Bao's (2024) concept of "forced digitalization", in which feminist discourse is driven online by censorship but paradoxically magnified by participatory algorithms. Therefore, posts vividly depicting the trauma of childbirth or criticizing male expectations often appear on popular pages, attracting women from all walks of life and all regions, otherwise they might be indifferent to politics.

This algorithmic diffusion is a double-edged sword mechanism. On the one hand, it standardizes feminist terms such as "maternal punishment" and "reproductive autonomy", allowing users to express potential frustration. On the other hand, it also magnifies the description of extreme pain or despair, which sometimes leads to what respondents call "political depression", that is, a sense of despair over institutional injustice, coupled with an

individual's avoidance of marriage and childbearing. The result is an expanded and emotionally polarized public domain: algorithmic curation extends the influence of feminists beyond the activist circle, while also intensifying the emotional risks of the fertility debate. This duality helps explain why feminist criticism has entered the mainstream of fertility discussions in China despite the continuous suppression by the government, and why online narratives can both mobilize and undermine the stability of young women's negotiations on fertility choices. The computational analysis of discourse patterns, particularly sentiment clustering around pain, policy frustration, and gender burden, reveals how digital infrastructures shape ideological diffusion even without explicit political intent.

Rewriting Motherhood

For a long time, the official remarks on fertility in China have been influenced by utilitarian goals, whether it was advocating "fewer children and more childbearing" during the family planning era or invoking patriotic responsibility under the three-child policy. This narrative casts woman's reproductive labor as a national service. Yet in recent years, cyberfeminism has increasingly deconstructed this logic, especially by exposing the state's withdrawal from institutional responsibility and its silence on the structural costs borne by women.

Rather than merely rejecting childbearing on ideological grounds, feminist voices online highlight the gap between glorified motherhood and systemic neglect. In one of the most telling findings from this study, with "economic burden" (7,672) and "pregnancy physical damage" (11,158) cited as the most frequent reasons to refuse motherhood, these reasons were also emotionally charged, "pregnancy physical damage" had the lowest average sentiment score (0.545).

Interviewees also echoed this resistance. One woman in her late twenties recalled crying in the delivery room without anesthesia yet was told by a nurse that "this is just what all mothers go through." Another respondent described returning to work three weeks

postpartum because her employer “doesn’t believe childbirth is an excuse for days off”. By circulating such stories, cyberfeminism has reshaped public discourse. The once-celebrated ideal of “glorious motherhood” becomes increasingly hollow in the face of institutional inaction. As one Douyin user wrote: “If motherhood is so sacred, why am I doing it alone and unpaid?”

The computational evidence in this paper demonstrates how such counter-narratives rise to prominence: clusters of comments containing keywords tied to bodily trauma or economic exploitation show higher co-occurrence probabilities with anti-natalist sentiments in topic modeling, yielding a discursive network in which state narratives are consistently challenged by experiential counter-stories. As state appeals lose credibility in these narrative environments, feminist discourse becomes a more persuasive cognitive framework for evaluating risk and autonomy.

Conditional Fertility as Strategic Negotiation

Facing persistent structural constraints, ranging from employment insecurity, unequal care burdens to insufficient fertility support, many Chinese women are actively exploring autonomous forms rather than passively succumbing to the dominant fertility expectations. According to quantitative analysis, public discourse surrounding fertility reveals an emotional landscape shaped by anxiety rather than indifference. These concerns were also reflected in the interview.

Rather than interpreting late marriage and late childbearing as signs of rejection, it is better to view them as temporary negotiation strategies. Statistical trends confirm that the average age of the first child in Chinese cities has now exceeded 30 (Wang, 2023). This delay has resonated politically. This is a game of patience. Women postpone their decisions until their conditions and roles are better recognized.

In multiple interviews, women expressed their desire to establish non-traditional kinship relationships, including cooperative families among same-sex friends and raising children alone abroad through egg freezing. Such a narrative emphasizes a collective imagination that reorganizes care, belonging and reproduction beyond the expectations of patriarchy. In this sense, "refusal" is best understood as a conditional stance that demands reciprocity and dignity before making a commitment. The autonomy here lies in conducting strategic negotiations within an unbalanced structure and increasingly expressing it through digital channels.

Quantitative data further indicates that this reflection is more widespread than what institutional narratives suggest. Among the 6,169 comments on the topic of "Mothers' Burden of Responsibility", a large proportion expressed regret over the emotional exhaustion and asymmetrical care needs that women bear. Compared with people of other categories, the average emotional score of this group is 0.668, which indicates that in addition to directly refusing to have children, there is a broader sense of ambivalence and frustration in daily life experiences.

These practices reveal the link between discourse-level critique and behavior-level adaptation. Women construct new imaginaries of family and belonging that challenge normative assumptions, illustrating how discursive resistance shapes lived experimentation. Every woman who calmly chooses a different timeline, partner configuration, or mode of intimacy is pushing the boundaries of what counts as a legitimate life.

Conclusion

This paper's mixed-method design, combining computational text analysis with qualitative interviews, reveals how digital discourse has become a central mechanism in reconfiguring reproductive autonomy in contemporary China. The findings show how structural critique, algorithmic encounters, feminist emotional currents, and strategic negotiation converge to

form a powerful counter-discourse. Cyberfeminism shifts reproduction from a nationally defined duty to a contested terrain of personal dignity, bodily risk, and structural injustice. Through quantitative mapping and qualitative interpretation, the study demonstrates that women's resistance is a renegotiation of the conditions under which future can be meaningfully pursued.

This thesis has examined how fertility in contemporary China has become a highly politicized and contested terrain, shaped by the intertwined forces of the state, society, and women themselves. National birth policy, whether restricting births in the past or urging higher fertility today, has consistently approached women's bodies as instruments for demographic goals, framing motherhood as both duty and service. Yet this utilitarian logic is increasingly unsettled by the rise of feminist subjectivities and the circulation of counter-discourse online. Drawing on both quantitative sentiment data and qualitative interview narratives, the study has shown that reproductive decisions are shaped solely by state imperatives or family expectations and by women's own assessments of autonomy. The findings bring into view the central role of fear, bodily experience, and caregiving burdens in shaping reproductive attitudes. Among the most frequently cited reasons for resisting childbirth were physical trauma, long-term health concerns, and unequal caregiving expectations, categories that carried some of the lowest sentiment scores in the dataset and were vividly echoed in interviews. Public incidents of gender-based violence, from the Fengxian chained mother case to the Tangshan restaurant attack, further intensified this reckoning, prompting women to question whether a system unable to protect basic safety can credibly demand more births. Rather than interpreting delayed marriage and childbearing as rejection, they should be seen as temporal strategies of negotiation. Statistical trends confirm that the average age of first childbirth in urban China now exceeds 30 (Wang, 2023). This deferral is politically resonant, a game of patience in which women postpone decisions until their conditions and agency are better recognized.

These contradictions also explain why merely relying on policy incentives: tax breaks, subsidies and extended holidays cannot change the behavior of having children. If the deeper conflicts among family ideals, economic instability and the burden of gender care remain unresolved, calls for

fertivism may intensify rather than soften resistance. Many women have clearly put forward the conditions under which they can accept having children: affordable child care services, fair workplace protection and genuine physical autonomy. Resistance turned into a kind of negotiation. Their strategies, whether seeking alternative kinship arrangements, freezing eggs abroad, or attempting cooperative living, have quietly expanded the possibility of a better life beyond the patriarchal script. A notable feature of this transformation lies in the role of algorithmic recommendation systems. Most respondents were not looking for feminist content. On the contrary, they were discovered by chance. This was an "algorithmic encounter" when they browsed Douyin or Xiaohongshu in their daily lives, making them realize their dissatisfaction in the broader pattern of structural inequality. Participatory algorithms, which aim to prioritize emotionally resonant content, unintentionally amplify feminist criticism, pushing it out of activist circles and into mainstream discourse. This process is a double-edged sword: while normalizing concepts such as "maternal punishment" or "reproductive autonomy", it also focuses on traumatic narratives, thereby triggering what some respondents call "political depression".

Despair: A state of high consciousness and hopelessness. Therefore, the digital dynamics that mobilize unity may also deepen the emotional polarization surrounding the debate on fertility. The resistance to state discourse is not merely oppositional. Cyberfeminist communities are also articulating constructive alternatives. From proposing Nordic-style parental leave systems to calling for reforms in reproductive health access and workplace protections, women are engaging with policy on their own terms. The growing visibility of these demands has already prompted limited responses in state language, such as new references to "women's employment security" in national plans (State Council, 2021). What emerges is a nuanced picture of feminist agency: one that resists domination, reclaims discourse, and envisions reform. By broadening the imagination of what a fulfilling female life looks like, feminist discourse destabilizes the assumption that happiness must be tied to motherhood. As feminist netizens repeat: "Childbirth is a right, not a duty."

At the same time, this kind of "conditional fertility" will profoundly be shaped by broader structural conditions. The imbalance in medical security and the high cost of giving birth force many women to weigh the potential economic and occupational costs in addition to the physical risks of pregnancy and childbirth. The gap in the childcare system means that motherhood is often accompanied by

career interruption and "motherhood penalties". Even in the presence of policy subsidies, the division of care within families and in the workplace remains highly gendered. As many respondents have pointed out, if there is a lack of affordable childcare services and stable labor security, the "more children" vision advocated by the state will only intensify women's anxiety and defensive mentality, rather than promoting their actual willingness to have children.

Looking ahead, the negotiation over reproductive meaning is unlikely to recede. As digital platforms continue to mediate encounters between personal experience and feminist critique, the contest over women's bodies will remain central to China's social and political future. A woman's refusal to give birth under forced conditions is neither indifferent nor selfish. This is a demand for recognition and justice. Policy responses that ignore this shift may exacerbate the sense of alienation. Those who center on the reality of life rather than abstract goals can pave the way for a more sustainable and fair treatment of family life. From this perspective, the transformation of women's fertility concepts is not merely a population issue; it reflects a deeper shift in social power, values, and discourse power.

Women are no longer merely the targets of governance; They are the main subjects of history, the drivers of change and the authors of new imagination. Their refusal to have children under compulsory conditions is a call for the establishment of a more livable country.

References

- Baer, H., & Ding, J. (2023). *How digital activism reshapes feminism?* Chinese Think Tank Network.
<https://www.chinathinktanks.org.cn/content/detail/id/r0i3q251>
- Bao, K. (2024). Comparative analysis of representations of feminism across Chinese social media: A corpus-based study of Weibo and Zhihu. *Social Media + Society*, 10(3), 1–13.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051241274688>
- Becker, G. S. (1991). *A treatise on the family* (Enlarged ed.). Harvard University Press.
- Chan, W., & Cheang, C. (2023). An examination of China's new fertility policy and its implications. *Frontiers in Political Science*, 5, Article 1278072.
- Chang, J., & Wang, M. (2022). Would household medical expenditure affect Chinese citizens to have more children? *Frontiers in Public Health*, 10, Article 902896.
<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2022.902896>
- Chen, Z., & Ding, L. (2024). Negotiation between ambition and reality: The path to Chinese feminist media's development. *Global Media and China*, 9(2), 140–156.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/20594364241230430>
- Chinese Communist Party & State Council. (2015). *Decision on implementing the universal two-child policy and reforming the management of family planning services*.
http://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2015-10/29/content_10251.htm
- Chinese Communist Party & State Council. (2021). *Decision on optimizing fertility policies and promoting long-term balanced development of the population*. http://www.gov.cn/zhengce/2021-07/20/content_5626190.htm
- Chu, H. (2023). The influence of the employment rights and interests of women of childbearing age under the background of “Three-Child” policy and its countermeasures. *Operations Research and Fuzziology*, 13(6), 6517–6529. <https://doi.org/10.12677/orf.2023.136643>

- Creswell, J. W., & Plano Clark, V. L. (2018). *Designing and conducting mixed methods research* (3rd ed.). SAGE Publications.
- Dai, Z. (2025, April 5). Maternal and child health adaptation to declining fertility in China. *The Lancet*, 405, 1142. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736\(25\)00413-1](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0140-6736(25)00413-1)
- Di, L., & Guo, J. (2021). Transgression and deviation: A study of female power narratives in contemporary film and television culture. In *Chinese Women's Culture* (Vol. 23, pp. xx–xx). Social Sciences Academic Press.
- Dong, W.-H., Wang, X., Yuan, F., Wang, L., Gu, T.-M., Zhu, B.-Q., & Shao, J. (2024). Will a government subsidy increase couples' further fertility intentions? A real-world study from a large-scale online survey in Eastern China. *Human Reproduction Open*, 2024(4), hoae055. <https://doi.org/10.1093/hropen/hoae055>
- Du, F. (n.d.). *The three obediences and four virtues and the seven grounds for divorce*. Chinese Culture (Chiculture.org.hk). https://chiculture.org.hk/sites/mainsite/files/2021-11/1002_sancongsideyuqichuzhitiao_yuanwen_hk.edited_1.pdf
- Du, Y., & Dong, H. (2024). Fertility policy adjustments and household fertility responses: An analysis from a social-stratification perspective. *Sociological Research*, (1), 46–68.
- Echo. (2021). Why women won't have children until it's worth it. *WeChat post*.
- Feng, E. (2021, September 9). China renews crackdown on online feminist groups. *Voice of America*. https://www.voanews.com/a/east-asia-pacific_china-renews-crackdown-online-feminist-groups/6205164.html
- Foucault, M. (1978). *The history of sexuality: Volume I – An introduction* (R. Hurley, Trans.). Pantheon Books.
- Ge, R., & Shi, X. (2021). How the universal two-child policy affects family fertility decisions. *Economic Quarterly*, 23(4), 1394–1408.

- Gong, C., & Li, C. (2015). Discussion on the “leftover women” issue in China and its social impact [论我国“剩女”问题及其社会影响]. *Chinese Youth Social Sciences*, 34(2), 21–41.
<https://doi.org/10.16034/j.cnki.10-1318/c.2015.02.003>
- Guttenberg, V. (2023). *Rice bunnies vs. the river crab: China’s feminists, #MeToo, and networked authoritarianism*. *FLUX: International Relations Review*, 31–39.
- Greenhalgh, S. (2024). Biopolitics of the three-child policy. *Made in China Journal*, 9(1), 52–61.
<https://doi.org/10.22459/MIC.09.01.2024.06>
- He, Y., Cheng, Y., & Deng, Z. (2022). A study on the concept of fertility under the evolution of female consciousness. *Advances in Social Sciences*, 11(6), 2171–2181.
<https://doi.org/10.12677/ass.2022.116298>
- Huang, R., Yu, J.-Y., He, W.-C., & Liu, R.-H. (2024). Feasibility analysis of China’s medical insurance coverage of assisted reproductive technology. *Scientific Reports*, 14, Article 7998.
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-024-58640-4>
- Human Rights in China. (2021). *Three-child policy, propaganda backlash, and public resistance in China* https://hricmedia.s3.us-west-1.amazonaws.com/_fad83d6f93.pdf
- Kanai, A. (2015). Thinking beyond the internet as a tool: Girls’ online spaces as postfeminist structures of surveillance. In J. Bailey & V. Steeves (Eds.), *eGirls, eCitizens* (pp. 83–106). University of Ottawa Press. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt15nmj7f.7>
- Li, Y. (2021). An analysis of the “new good-wife-and-wise-mother” ideology in the 1920s–1930s. In *Studies on Family and Women’s Culture* (Vol. 7). Institute of Qing History, Renmin University of China. <http://iqh.ruc.edu.cn/>
<https://doi.org/10.3389/fpos.2023.1278072>
- Liao, J.-Y., Kong, Y., & Zhou, T. (2021). *Quantifying the efficacy of childcare services on women employment*. arXiv. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2103.13570>

- Ma, C. (2020). The Chinese predicament of feminism: A thematic analysis of the “pastoral female slave” discourse on Zhihu (Master’s thesis). Central China Normal University, Hubei, China.
- MacKinnon, C. A. (1989). *Toward a feminist theory of the state*. Harvard University Press.
- Mao, C. (2020). Feminist activism via social media in China. *Asian Journal of Women’s Studies*, 26(2), 245–258. <https://doi.org/10.1080/12259276.2020.1767844>
- Master, F., & Chen, L. (2024, August 21). *China’s fresh urbanisation push may thwart ‘birth-friendly society’ goal*. Reuters. <https://www.reuters.com/world/china/chinas-fresh-urbanisation-push-may-thwart-birth-friendly-society-goal-2024-08-21/>
- Milford, T. S. (2015). Revisiting cyberfeminism: Theory as a tool for understanding young women’s experiences. In J. Bailey & V. Steeves (Eds.), *eGirls, eCitizens* (pp. 51–81). University of Ottawa Press. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt15nmj7f.6>
- National Bureau of Statistics of China. (2023). *Statistical communique of the People’s Republic of China on the 2022 national economic and social development*.
http://www.stats.gov.cn/english/PressRelease/202302/t20230228_1919006.html
- Ni, Y. (2025, February). The promotion of digital feminism on Chinese social media. *Highlights in Business, Economics and Management*, 47, 179–186. <https://doi.org/10.54097/axrbgt58>
- Renmin Think Tank. (2023, May 16). *Survey report on Chinese public fertility attitudes (2023)*. Renmin Forum & China National Governance Network.
<http://www.rmlt.com.cn/2023/0516/673409.shtml>
- Shen, Y., & Jiang, L. (2022). *The new era of fertility*. Social Sciences Academic Press.
- State Council of the People’s Republic of China. (2021). *Program for the development of Chinese women* [Policy document]. Beijing: State Council.
- Tan, J., & Kang, S. (2021). *Urban housing prices and migration’s fertility intentions: Based on the 2018 China migrants’ dynamic survey* (Preprint No. 2112.07273). arXiv.

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2112.07273>

- Tong, X. (2020). The formation and development of a feminist cognitive community. *Journal of Shanxi Normal University (Social Science Edition)*, (9), 64–70.
- UNFPA China. (2025, March 8). *Childcare Services Support Women's Labour Force Participation and Economic Contributions*. UNFPA China. <https://china.unfpa.org/en/news/25030801>
- Van Houten, C. (2015). Simone de Beauvoir Abroad: Historicizing Maoism and the Women's Liberation Movement. *Comparative Literature Studies*, 52(1), 112–129.
<https://doi.org/10.5325/complitstudies.52.1.0112>
- Voice of America. (2024, March 7). Chinese women resist calls for marriage and parenthood. *VOA Chinese*. <https://www.voachinese.com/a/chinese-women-resist-calls-for-marriage-and-parenthood/7911172.html>
- Wang, Y., & Tavmen, G. (2024). New outlets of digital feminist activism in China: The #SeeFemaleWorkers campaign. *Feminist Media Studies*. Advance online publication.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/14680777.2024.2334782>
- Wang, Z. (2004). The globalization and localization of women's studies: On the translation of “gender” and its implications. *Academic Frontiers*, 19–32.
- Wang, Z. (2023). *Survey on women's fertility intention in large cities* [Research report]. Renmin Forum & China National Governance Network.
<http://www.rmlt.com.cn/2023/0516/673409.shtml>
- Yang, L., Liu, Z., & Yao, T. (2024). Research progress on intergenerational transmission of fertility intentions. *Economic Dynamics*, 8, 145–160.
- Yang, Y. (2024). Ambivalent effects of anger in Chinese feminists' refusal to patriarchal marriage and family. *Social Movement Studies*. Advance online publication.
- Yaya. (2023, July 19). The rise and dilemmas of online feminism in China. *Chinese Feminism*.

<https://chinesefeminism.org/2023/07/19/yaya-online-feminism/>

Yu, H. (2007). An analysis of the “new good-wife-and-wise-mother” ideology in 1920s–1930s China. *Journal of Humanities*, (3), 104–110.

Yu, J., & Wang, X. (2023). *Research report on the impact of the three-child policy on women's reproductive rights in China*. Chinese Gender Policy Watch.

<https://www.genderpolicywatch.cn/report-threechild-rights>

Yuval-Davis, N. (1997). *Gender and nation*. SAGE Publications.

Zhang, C., Wei, L., Zhu, Y. *et al.* Fertility intentions among young people in the era of China’s three–child policy: a national survey of university students. *BMC Pregnancy Childbirth* **22**, 637 (2022). <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12884-022-04873-y>

Zhang, E., & Zhao, J. (2023). Reflections on the phenomenon of “Chinese rural feminism” from the perspective of the Marxist view on women. *Social Sciences Journal of Universities in Shanxi*, 35(2), 33–37. <https://doi.org/10.16396/j.cnki.sxgxsxb.2023.02.006>

Zhong, R. (2022). The end of Roe v. Wade has parallels to China’s one-child policy. *World Politics Review*. <https://www.worldpoliticsreview.com/in-china-abortion-and-state-control-go-hand-in-hand/>